INNOVATION SCHOOL · DESIGN THINKING · UNDERSTAND + EMPATHIZE

AI Maturity in Our Team

A working session with six senior engineers to understand where the wider team actually stands — and to leave with a problem statement we can act on.

- 6 senior engineers
- backend · frontend · testing
- 60 minutes
- Base for the monthly Learning Transfer Goal

RAIFFEISEN TECH · OCTOBER 2026

OPEN WITH “You are here as the people closest to the work — not to be assessed. We need your read on where the wider team of ~20 actually stands, and what is really in the way.”

THE FRAME

Why we're here

Understand

Build a shared picture of where the **wider team of ~20** actually is — from the people who work closest to them.

Empathize

Surface the barriers in people's own words — real tickets, real constraints, real frustrations.

BY THE END OF THIS HOUR WE WILL HAVE

1 · A shared picture

Where the wider team clusters — and where the spread is.

2 · The real barriers

Clustered stories, not opinions. What actually blocks progress.

3 · A problem statement

One sentence — grounded in hypotheses and assumptions we can test.

🚫 **Not today:** individual assessment, performance reviews, or tool decisions. You are the observers — the wider team is the subject.

SAY THIS "I'm not asking you to rate yourselves. I'm asking: if you look across the team, where do most people sit? What do you see that I don't?"

FRAMEWORK

The five AI maturity levels

1	**Dictating**	Gives short, step-by-step instructions — one action at a time	ONE PROMPT → ONE ACTION
2	**Commanding**	Writes an execution plan, then hands it to the agent as a batch order	PLAN BY HUMAN, AI EXECUTES
3	**Regulating**	Co-authors the plan with the agent — rules define the "how"	RULES CARRY THE HOW
4	**Orchestrating**	Agents propose plans; humans review at phase boundaries	WORKFLOW IS CODIFIED
5	**Supervising**	Ticket in → deployable output out. Humans review the evidence	FULL WORKFLOW

📍 **Our starting assumption:** most of the wider team sits between Level 1 and Level 2. A few strong engineers touch early Level 3. Today is where we test that assumption — with your eyes, not a test.

KEEP IT SHORT 90 seconds on the ladder. The definitions are on the slide — let people read them. Move to the target quickly.

THE TARGET FOR OUR TEAM

FRAMEWORK

Why Level 3 is the next step

⭐ **This is the highest-value transition for us.** Not Level 5 — Level 3. It is close, it is practical, and it changes how everything after it works.

	LEVEL 2 — WHERE WE THINK MOST PEOPLE ARE	LEVEL 3 — WHERE WE WANT THE TEAM TO BE
Who writes the plan	Human writes the full plan	**AI drafts the plan from the ticket + rules; human refines it**
Where the "how" lives	Repeated inside every prompt and plan	**Lives in standing rules (AGENTS.md / constitution)**
Starting a ticket	Human supplies the sequence and constraints	**Human gives intent + the ticket-specific twist**
Corrections	Fixed ad-hoc for this ticket	**Become permanent rules or skills**

🧠 **The mindset shift:** Level 3 is not "longer prompts". It is moving the repeated "how" out of conversations and into rules the agent always loads.

ASK "Which row of this table do you see most often on the wider team's tickets?" That answer is a barrier in disguise — write it down for the discussion.

THE SWITCH THAT FLIPS LEVEL 3 ON

One rule in AGENTS.md

FRAMEWORK

AGENTS.md

```
# Standing rule — always active

Before implementing any change, propose a short plan:
  • What you will touch
  • What you will leave alone
  • Which tests you will run

Then wait for approval before coding.
```

❌ **Without this line**

The agent starts implementing. The human becomes a reviewer of finished work instead of a co-author of the plan.

✅ **With this line**

Co-authoring becomes the default. The plan appears **before** code — so the human steers early, when it is cheap.

📝 **Rule of thumb:** if you typed it twice, it belongs in AGENTS.md. If you typed it three times, it belongs in a skill.

SAY THIS "This is one paragraph. If the wider team adopted only this, we would move a large part of them from Level 2 to early Level 3."

DISCUSSION · 15 MINUTES

Where does the [redacted] stand?

Think across the ~20 engineers — not yourself. Where would you place the majority? Where is the spread? What do you see on their tickets that tells you where they are?

- Observe the wider team, not yourselves
- Place the team on the ladder
- Look for the cluster, not the outliers

FACILITATOR PROMPT

"If you had to draw the distribution of the ~20 on this ladder, what would it look like? Where is the thickest part?"

DO THIS Draw five columns on the whiteboard. Ask each senior to place a sticky where they think the **MEDIAN** of the wider team sits — then a second sticky for where the **TOP QUARTILE** sits. The gap between them is the story.

DISCUSSION · 15 MINUTES

What's [redacted] in the way?

Think of the tickets you have seen from the wider team. Where do they get stuck? What makes the next level feel hard, slow, or risky for them — in their words, not yours?

- Stories about the wider team
- Barriers, not solutions
- Cluster as you go

IF THE ROOM IS QUIET

"What is the most common thing you find yourself correcting in other people's agent interactions?"

LISTEN FOR three distinct barriers: "they don't know how" (knowledge), "they don't trust it" (confidence), "there's no time" (capacity). Each needs a different response. Name them on the board as they appear.

Our working hypotheses

H1 We believe **most of the wider team is at Level 2** — writing the full plan themselves — because the standing rules are incomplete or not loaded.

We'll know we're right if the seniors report that agents rarely propose a plan unprompted.

H2 We believe **repeated corrections are rarely turned into shared rules or skills** — so the same mistakes recur across the team.

We'll know we're right if the seniors cannot point to a rule that was added because of a correction.

H3 We believe **shared skills and prompts exist but are hard to discover**, so people rewrite from scratch instead of reusing.

We'll know we're right if the seniors say most people have never browsed the shared library.

H4 *[Your hypothesis from today's discussion — write it together.]*

Format: We believe ___ because ___. We'll know we're right if ___.

🧪 **These are hypotheses about the wider team — not conclusions.** They get validated with the ~20 before we commit to any change.

WRITE H4 LIVE Leave this slide open for a minute. Whatever the group converges on goes into the empty card — in their words, not yours.

Our assumptions — and how we'd test them

ASSUMPTION 01

The wider team is genuinely between Level 1 and Level 2.

Validate: run a light, anonymous pulse-check with the ~20 next month.

ASSUMPTION 02

These six seniors' read on the wider team is representative.

Validate: cross-check with frontend and testing engineers not in this room.

ASSUMPTION 03

The bottleneck is practice and rules — not tooling or access.

Validate: ask directly whether anyone on the wider team is blocked by setup.

ASSUMPTION 04

People will share honestly in a safe, anonymised setting.

Validate: compare what the seniors say privately with what the wider team reports.

ASSUMPTION 05 — YOURS

[What are we quietly assuming about the wider team that we haven't said out loud?]

Validate: _____

🔍 **Why this matters:** unnamed assumptions become invisible decisions. Naming them is part of the Understand phase.

ASK "What are we assuming about the wider team that, if wrong, would change everything?" That usually produces the most valuable assumption of the session.

How Might We...

01 How might we help the wider team move from writing every plan themselves to co-authoring plans with the agent — without losing quality control?

02 How might we make the repeated “how” live in rules the agent always loads, so people across the team stop retyping it?

03 How might we turn every correction on the wider team's tickets into a permanent rule or skill — without adding process overhead?

04 *[Your HMW from today's barriers — write it together.]*

💡 **Good HMW test:** broad enough to allow many solutions, narrow enough to be answerable. If it contains a solution, it's not a HMW yet.

WRITE 04 LIVE Take the top barrier from the discussion and convert it into a HMW. Read it back to the room — “Does this feel like the right question?”

THE SYNTHESIS · WHAT WE NOW UNDERSTAND

The wider team's biggest lever is the *Level 2 → Level 3 transition* — moving the repeated "how" out of conversations and into standing rules, so agents propose plans and humans refine them.

We believe the barrier is **practice and rules, not tooling**. Before committing to any change, we will validate this with the wider team of ~20 — starting with the assumptions and hypotheses the seniors named today.

Understand ✓ | Empathize ✓ | Hypotheses named | Assumptions named | HMWs drafted

LAND IT Read the statement out loud slowly. Then pause. Ask: "Does this feel true when you think about the wider team?" If someone hesitates, that hesitation is the most valuable thing in the room — explore it before you close.